

The morning ferry crosses the estuary twice before the tide turns, carrying commuters, bicycles and crates of vegetables from the farms on the far shore. Nobody on board hurries; they read, drink tea from flasks and watch the herons stand in the shallows. When the ferry docks, a short queue forms along the jetty and the deckhand coils the rope with practised ease.

A well-made map leaves out far more than it shows. The cartographer decides which roads matter, which rivers deserve a name and where a label may sit without hiding a village. Every choice trades detail for clarity, and the reader trusts the result because the trades were made carefully and applied the same way across the whole sheet.

In the workshop the lamps stay lit late. Shavings gather under the bench, a kettle ticks as it cools, and the half-finished chair waits for its last joint. The maker steps back, squints along the rail and decides that tomorrow will do for the glue, since good work is not improved by being rushed past the point of care.

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